Seeing with Sound: How Some Blind People 'Click' to Navigate

From: Science News Explores Mined: 2026-06-02 3 min read

Close your eyes. Can you tell where a wall is just by making a sound? Some blind people can! It's called **echolocation**. They make a sharp click with their tongue and listen for the echo that bounces back. Bats do the same thing to fly in the dark.

Scientists wanted to know how this works in the brain. So they asked four blind **echolocation** experts and 21 **sighted** people to listen to recorded clicks and echoes. The sounds were like an object was nearby, either on the left or right. After hearing a few clicks, they had to guess the object's direction. While they listened, a cap with **electrodes** measured their **brain activity**.

The blind experts were amazing. One person could tell the direction after just two sets of clicks! The **sighted** people couldn't do that. The brain scans showed something cool: with each new click-echo pair, the experts' brains added more details to a **mental picture**. It's like putting together puzzle pieces, one click at a time.

"This is not magic," said scientist Santani Teng. "Echolocators have a truly **remarkable** skill, with real-life benefits." The researchers now want to find out how experts learn to ignore their own click and focus only on the echo. That's the next puzzle to solve!

Word Treasure

echolocation -- Using sound echoes to figure out where objects are, like a bat does.
electrodes -- Small sensors that can measure tiny electrical signals from the brain.
brain activity -- The work your brain does when it thinks or senses something.
mental picture -- An image you create in your mind using your other senses.
sighted -- People who can see.
remarkable -- Very special or amazing; worth noticing.

Background you need

Bats and dolphins use echolocation naturally, but some humans can learn to do it too.

Daniel Kish, a blind man, is famous for using clicks to ride a bike and hike in the woods.

Scientists like Santani Teng study how the brain processes echoes to build a 'picture' of the world.

Break it down

WHO: Four blind echolocation experts and 21 sighted people, with scientist Santani Teng

WHAT: The experts' brains built detailed mental pictures from click echoes, one puzzle piece at a time.

WHERE: In a research lab using a cap with electrodes to measure brain activity

WHY: To learn how the brain processes echoes, which could help teach more blind people to 'see' with sound.

Why it matters

This shows that your brain can learn amazing ways to sense the world, even without eyes -- and one day, more blind people might gain freedom through clicking.

Test what you remember

1. **What is the skill called where blind people click their tongue to navigate?**
   - (A) Echolocation
   - (B) Echo-reading
   - (C) Sound-seeing
   - (D) Click-walking
2. **Which animal also uses echolocation?**
   - (A) Bats
   - (B) Dogs
   - (C) Eagles
   - (D) Sharks
3. **How many blind echolocation experts took part in the study?**
   - (A) 4
   - (B) 21
   - (C) 2
   - (D) 12
4. **What did the cap with electrodes measure?**
   - (A) Brain activity
   - (B) Heart rate
   - (C) Eye movement
   - (D) Breathing speed
5. **What did the experts' brains do with each new click-echo pair?**
   - (A) Added more details to a mental picture
   - (B) Ignored the echo
   - (C) Became confused
   - (D) Stopped working
6. **According to scientist Santani Teng, what is echolocation?**
   - (A) A truly remarkable skill with real-life benefits
   - (B) Magic
   - (C) A simple trick anyone can learn
   - (D) Not very useful

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: A 3: A 4: A 5: A 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Positive: Echolocation gives blind people a free, natural way to navigate without expensive tools.

2. Critical: Learning echolocation takes a lot of practice, and not all blind people can master it.

3. Neutral: Researching the brain's ability to adapt helps scientists find new ways to assist people with disabilities.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):